HOW KIDS EAT

A Thanksgiving Nature Documentary

Written and directed by Amanda Young for ACS

A short skit in five specimens

Sixth Grade Thanksgiving Program

Running time, about 7 minutes

Cast of 7

Version 5, updated October 21, 2026

CAST

NARRATOR	*clipboard, safari hat, a stopwatch, very serious*
MOM	*patient, undefeated*
NOODLE KID	*the sensory eater, nothing may touch*
PEA KID	*the kid who eats nothing*
THE TALKER	*fork up, it never lands*
SHOVEL KID	*the speed eater, rice and gravy*
SECONDS KID	*the overeater*

THE SET

One long table facing the audience, with the chairs behind it so the audience sees every plate. A fake plant at one end. A real dog lies under the table, with its owner just offstage.

STAGING NOTES

- Keep everything turned out toward the audience. If the audience cannot see the plate, the joke is gone.
- Use safe stand-in food. Real dry rice, plastic peas, plain cooked noodles. Nobody actually eats on stage, except the dog.
- The handful Pea Kid passes under the table must be REAL dog-safe food (a plain cooked pea or a dog treat), never the plastic peas. Rehearse it with the dog once so it knows to wait there.
- Put a tarp or an old sheet under Shovel Kid.
- Once a kid has had their scene, they stay seated at the table, so the whole family is there for the pie.
- The Narrator carries the show. Cast a kid who can keep a straight face.

OPENING

THE TABLE

(The Narrator tiptoes in, clipboard up, and crouches beside the table.)

NARRATOR. *(hushed)* The fourth Thursday of November. A rare and dangerous day. Today, we observe the North American Sixth Grader as it approaches the most feared event of its year. Thanksgiving dinner.

NARRATOR. There are five known kinds of eater. Tonight, we will observe them all. *(whisper)* Stay very still.

SPECIMEN ONE

THE SENSORY EATER

(Noodle Kid enters with a plate of fettuccine, sits, and lays out a napkin like a tray of surgical tools.)

NARRATOR. The subject has been served fettuccine.

NOODLE KID. Scalpel.

NARRATOR. It has not been served fettuccine. It has been served a problem. Every bite must pass inspection. Color. Texture. Temperature. Attitude.

(Noodle Kid begins removing things one at a time, holding each one up to the light, then setting it on the napkin.)

NOODLE KID. Green thing. *(sets it down)* Green thing. Green speck. Suspicious green speck. *(squints)* Mushroom. In my HOUSE.

NARRATOR. Note the precision. Not one flake of parsley will survive.

(Noodle Kid starts wiping the sauce off the noodles one at a time and lining them up in a row.)

NARRATOR. It has now removed the sauce. The sauce is the food. *(beat)* Not to this one.

(Noodle Kid holds up a plate with about four bare noodles on it and beams. The Narrator quietly rolls a cranberry across the table. It touches the plate. Noodle Kid stares in silent horror.)

NOODLE KID. *(quiet, shaking)* It touched.

NARRATOR. Contact.

NOODLE KID. *(standing, to the whole room)* IT TOUCHED.

NARRATOR. The plate is now considered contaminated.

(Noodle Kid sits, eats one noodle from the far edge of the plate, and pushes the rest away.)

NOODLE KID. I'm full.

NARRATOR. Eleven minutes of work. One noodle.

(Noodle Kid slides down to the end of the table with great dignity, leaving behind a napkin piled with the entire meal.)

SPECIMEN TWO

THE KID WHO EATS NOTHING

(Pea Kid sits with both arms folded, staring at a full plate. Mom stands over the chair.)

NARRATOR. Some subjects survive the entire holiday on nothing at all. Scientists still do not know how.

MOM. Two bites. I'm getting the gravy. Do not move.

(Mom exits. The second she is gone, Pea Kid springs into action, checking over both shoulders before every move. The Narrator calls it like a golf tournament.)

NARRATOR. *(whisper)* Into the milk.

(Pea Kid drops peas into the glass. Looks pleased. Then notices the milk is now green, and slides the glass down the table.)

NARRATOR. Bold. Into the mashed potatoes.

(Pea Kid buries a spoonful and pats it smooth like a tiny grave.)

NARRATOR. Into the plant.

(Pea Kid stretches way out, dumps peas into the plant, and sits back innocently.)

NARRATOR. Into the sock. *(looks up, genuinely concerned)* Into the sock?

(Pea Kid lifts one leg onto the chair and pours peas in. Sits back. Nods.)

NARRATOR. And finally, the oldest partnership in nature.

(Pea Kid slowly lowers a hand under the table. The dog eats from it, and its tail wags out from under the tablecloth.)

PEA KID. Good boy. You're the only one who gets me.

(Mom returns with the gravy and looks at the empty plate. Long pause.)

MOM. You ate it?

PEA KID. Every bite.

(Pea Kid stands up, and peas pour out of the napkin, the sleeve, the sock, everywhere. Mom just looks.)

PEA KID. . . . I'll get those later.

NARRATOR. The subject has eaten nothing. Again.

(Mom exits with the gravy. Pea Kid sits back down.)

SPECIMEN THREE

THE TALKER

(The Talker sits down in the middle of the table with a full plate, picks up a fork, raises it, and starts talking. The fork does not come down.)

THE TALKER. So this one time at recess, okay, me and Jaden, no wait, it was Mason. No, it was Jaden. We were by the swings,

NARRATOR. The talker. Its fork has been raised for some time. Observe. The fork approaches the mouth.

(The fork gets almost all the way in. The Talker pulls it back out to point with it.)

THE TALKER. and THEN the ball goes over the fence,

NARRATOR. And it retreats.

(Mom enters and starts clearing the table, and slides the Talker's full plate out from under the fork.)

THE TALKER. so Jaden says, actually it was Mason, so Mason says,

NARRATOR. The food is now cold. The food is now gone.

THE TALKER. and that is why we can't go by the swings anymore. *(finally lowers the fork, looks down)* Hey. Where's my food?

MOM. Dinner was an hour ago.

THE TALKER. *(outraged)* I didn't even get to eat! *(beat)* Okay, that reminds me of a story.

(Mom exits fast. The Talker keeps talking, silently, for the rest of the play.)

SPECIMEN FOUR

THE SPEED EATER

(Shovel Kid enters at a sprint with a heaping plate of rice and gravy, and sits. The Narrator pulls out a stopwatch.)

NARRATOR. Rice and gravy. Brace yourself. *(clicks the stopwatch)*

(Shovel Kid eats like the plate is about to be taken away. No pauses. No breathing. Rice flies everywhere, and one grain lands on the forehead.)

NARRATOR. No chewing has been observed. He is not tasting it. He is storing it.

(Shovel Kid slams the fork down and sits back, totally serene.)

NARRATOR. *(clicks the stopwatch)* Four seconds. A new record.

SHOVEL KID. *(polite, a grain of rice on the forehead)* May I please be excused?

NARRATOR. Note the excellent manners.

SHOVEL KID. *(eyeing Noodle Kid's plate)* Are you gonna finish that?

(Noodle Kid pulls the plate in close and guards it with both arms.)

SPECIMEN FIVE

THE OVEREATER

(Seconds Kid enters with a plate piled so high it takes both arms and a chin to hold it.)

NARRATOR. And now, the largest specimen of all. Not in size. In appetite.

SECONDS KID. *(sitting)* Just a little plate. I'm not that hungry.

(Seconds Kid eats it all and holds up the empty plate. Mom swoops in and refills it. Again. Again, faster.)

NARRATOR. Seconds. Thirds. *(flipping pages on the clipboard)* I have lost count.

(Seconds Kid builds a pyramid of dinner rolls and growls at anyone who reaches for one.)

SECONDS KID. Those are for later.

NARRATOR. It is now later.

(Seconds Kid eats the pyramid, leans back, and groans.)

SECONDS KID. I'm so full. I'm never eating again. I mean it this time.

NARRATOR. It cannot possibly fit any more.

FINALE

PIE

(The whole table is groaning, stuffed, draped over the chairs.)

PEA KID. I'm so full.

NOODLE KID. I can't move.

SHOVEL KID. I may never eat again.

THE TALKER. Okay, so this one time,

EVERYONE. SHHH.

NARRATOR. The herd has reached capacity. There is no room left. None whatsoever.

(Mom enters carrying a pie.)

MOM. Who wants pie?

(Everyone snaps upright at once. Plates out, hands up. Seconds Kid is already holding a fork.)

ALL. ME!

NARRATOR. *(to the audience)* Fascinating. They will not eat their vegetables. They will not let their food touch. They will hide peas in a sock. But they show up. Every single year. To the same table. With the same people.

NARRATOR. *(dropping the documentary voice)* And that is kind of the whole point.

EVERYONE. Happy Thanksgiving!

(Everyone dives for the pie. Blackout.)

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